



## SANTORINI GREECE

## Golden Fava on Santorini

A magnet for honeymooners, Santorini has more five-star hotels and fancy restaurants than any other Greek island. Yet its signature dish, fava, is a humble staple food. This golden bean purée owes its rich, nutty flavor to Santorini's volcanic terrain. An eruption blew out the heart of the island 3,500 years ago, and this natural disaster proved an unexpected blessing for fava farmers.



Its red cliffs frosted with whitewashed hamlets and fringed with black sand beaches, Santorini has a savage beauty.

The volcanic eruption that created the flooded caldera, or basin, in 1500 BC also buried the island's biggest settlement at Akrotiri. This Bronze Age city was discovered barely 30 years ago, buried beneath 33 ft (10 m) of ash. Recreations of the stunning frescoes unearthed at Akrotiri are on display in the island's capital, Fira, which can be reached by a thrilling cable-car ride from the port of Gialos.

The dramatic landscape makes for wondrous sunsets, but made it difficult for locals to eke out a living until the advent of tourism. Only a few crops can be coaxed from the island's arid soil – succulent grapes, sweet white eggplants, cherry tomatoes bursting with flavor, piquant capers, and the resilient fava bean. More prized (and much pricier) than fava grown elsewhere in Greece, this plain little bean has been cultivated on Santorini since the Bronze Age, its flat plants able to absorb moisture from the porous pumice stone. After harvesting, the beans are left to dry, then stripped of their brown husks to reveal yellow grains, bright as jewels.

Primarily a Lenten food in much of Greece, fava is eaten year-round on Santorini and always served warm. Simmered gently until it dissolves into a smooth paste, fava remains a popular foil for seafood – it forms a pillowy bed for octopus stewed in sweet wine, salty sardines, or crunchy calamari rings. Amazingly versatile, it might be topped with raw onions, doused in lemon, or flecked with dill. *Fava pandremeni* (“married fava”) is a lyrical euphemism for leftover fava jazzed up with fried onions, capers, and a swirl of tomato paste. The less evocative *fava tis grias* (“crone’s fava”) is a winter variation with smoked pork. As it cools, a well is made in the fava and filled with olive oil; hence the Greek expression “there’s a hole in the fava,” which loosely translates as “there’s something fishy going on.”

Once a peasant food, fava is now an expensive gourmet product cultivated by fewer than 200 farmers. Most producers focus instead on the island's wines, following a tradition as old as Akrotiri. Vaulted wine cellars and humble cave dwellings have been converted into glamorous hotels teetering on the brink of the volcano, with infinity pools suspended between sky and sea. They make ideal vantage points from which to ponder whether the flooded crater does indeed conceal the lost city of Atlantis.

### Three Days on Santorini

For all its black-sand beaches and wealth of antiquities, Santorini's main attraction is the spellbinding volcanic caldera. Boat trips to and around the islets are a must.

**DAY ONE** Sailing into the caldera is like floating into an open-air geological museum. Sizzling in the center is the crater of **Nea Kameni**, which you can climb if you dare. Wallow in the hot springs of **Palea Kameni**, then shin up the **Islet of Thirassia** to **Manolas**, a clifftop time-warped with astonishing views of the archipelago.

**DAY TWO** Hike the daredevil path running along the rim of the caldera from **Fira** to **Oia**, the quintessential Cycladic village. Zigzag down the red cliffs for just-caught fish and iced ouzo at **Ammoudi**, a fishing port with half a dozen good tavernas.

**DAY THREE** Admire reproductions of the frescoes unearthed at Akrotiri at the Petros Nomikos Foundation in **Fira**. Travel south from Fira to **Vothonos**, where you can buy top-quality fava beans to take home at the **Yiannis Nomikos Estate**. Continue onward to **Pyrgos**, a beautifully preserved village built around a medieval castle.

### Essentials

#### GETTING THERE

There are direct flights to **Santorini Airport** from Europe, and regular domestic flights from Athens. The high-speed **ferry** from Athens takes about five hours.

#### WHERE TO STAY

**Zannos Melathron** (moderate) is a grand manor house in Pyrgos. [www.zannos.gr](http://www.zannos.gr)  
**Kapari** (moderate) has spectacular caldera views and snug rooms. [www.kaparisantorini.gr](http://www.kaparisantorini.gr)  
**Perivolos** (expensive) offers laid-back luxury on the outskirts of Oia. [www.perivolos.gr](http://www.perivolos.gr)

#### FURTHER INFORMATION

[www.santorini.net](http://www.santorini.net)

